

once. Twice would be asking for trouble.

‘Rs 5,000 fixed, plus jobbing commissions,’ I said.

‘You are worth much more. I will pay you Rs 15,000 plus jobbing commissions; join me from next month,’ he said.

Perhaps it was the tone of the proposal that put me off. It sounded more like an order than an offer. But then, Manubhai was never really known to charm people. ‘I am quite happy with what my boss is paying me right now. Besides, he gave me a job when nobody else was willing to take me on. I can’t walk out on him just for some extra money,’ I said.

He did not realize that had he been a bit more tactful, I could have easily been persuaded to cross over. After all, who would not want to work with one of the biggest names on Dalal Street? But if he thought he could buy me out with just money, he was mistaken.

Manubhai was a bit taken aback by my answer. I guess he was not used to being rebuffed by a jobber barely a year into the profession.

‘Good to hear that you still treasure old-world values like loyalty, otherwise everybody is out here to get rich quick by whatever means possible. If ever you are in need of a job, you can always call on me,’ he said, walking away without waiting for my response.

Soon after that he gave me a couple of decent-sized orders, which I managed to execute well. But more important than the commissions they fetched me was the relief I felt in knowing that he still thought sufficiently well of me to give me business.